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Volunteers are vital part of operation at Raptor Center

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The Carolina Raptor Center depends on volunteers for its day to day operations and for the preservation and rehabilitation of birds of prey — volunteers like Tom Rouse of Concord.



Rouse

Raptors are birds of prey, such as eagles, owls, hawks, falcons and vultures. They have a hooked bill and sharp talons or claws used for hunting.

Rouse said he became inter-

ested in being a volunteer at the Raptor Center after he saw an exhibit from the Carolina Raptor Center in a shopping mall.

"The exhibit I saw was very interesting, and I decided to join the Raptor Center as a member," Rouse said.

He has been there for 14 months, helping out at the center about once a week. "It's usually on Sunday. I give educational shows in the weathering area. The weathering area is a small area where birds are brought out into the open by handlers," he said.

The weathering area gives the public a chance to see a birds up close, without bars or wire obstructing the view. "A lot of

people like to photograph the birds at this time," he said. There are about 65 birds involved in the educational programs.

Volunteers, like Rouse, go through an extensive training program. Rouse said he remembers how he felt the first time he had a bird of prey sit on his forearm. "I was a little apprehensive the first time I had a bird on my arm. It was a red-tailed hawk named Sigmon. He was an intimidating bird," he said.

Raptors are very powerful birds, with strong claws and sharp bills. A raptor could easily damage one's arm or face if the person handling it is not properly

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A couple of Raptor Center inhabitants

trained.

Rouse said the center uses all types of volunteers. Landscape volunteers plant flowers and shrubs. There are also office helpers and fundraisers. He said there are raptor volunteers in almost every county in North Carolina.

"All the volunteers work as a team. If an injured bird is found somewhere, it can be transported by a network of volunteers who can take it from one point to another until it reaches the center in Charlotte," he said.

Rouse remembers when two great horned owls were retrieved from someone in Rowan County by a wildlife officer. It is illegal to possess a bird of prey without a permit.

Rouse said he was called to pick up the birds. "The owls were in a cardboard box that was missing one of its flaps and was held together with duct tape. I put the box in the back seat of my car.

"Well, one of the owls got out of the box and was loose in the back seat. I pulled off the road as quickly as possible. I always carry a cardboard box and leather gloves in the trunk of my car. You never know when you'll be called to get an injured bird or see one yourself.

"I was able to catch it and put it in the better box. I took the owls to work with me, and another volunteer picked them up from there and took them to the Raptor Center."

When a bird is brought to the center, it is examined and treated for injuries right away. Local veterinarians perform free x-rays and surgery on the birds, said Pat Marcum, executive director at the Carolina Raptor Center. Some birds are releasable and others are not, she said.

Marcum said volunteers like Rouse are important to the center's sustenance.

"Tom is a dedicated and conscientious volunteer and is a perfect example of the 120 volunteers we have here at the center," she said.

The center is not funded by the state and depends solely on donations and memberships to pay for operating costs. Individuals, corporations and foundations can help the center by purchasing memberships, she said.

The Carolina Raptor Center is located on Sample Road in the Latta Plantation Park. For more information about the center call (704) 875-6521.